

MITSUE MOTHER TREE PROJECT

Documenting Mitsue's Trees — A School Program Proposal

To: Mitsue Elementary School (and Junior High) — 〒 633-1302 奈良県宇陀郡御杖村大字菅野2470 · Tel (0745)-95-2516 · mitsuesyogakkou@vill.mitsue.nara.jp **From:** Rob Oudendijk — Mitsue Mother Tree Project · **Date:** 2026-07-02

1. In one sentence

We invite Mitsue's schoolchildren to become the village's **young forest scientists** — walking their own mountains to find, photograph and map Mitsue's great native trees, using a simple bilingual phone/tablet app and a printed field guide, as a **summer project** or a recurring part of the **school year**.

2. Why this matters for Mitsue

- **The forest is Mitsue's future.** The village's renewable-energy plan and the Mother Tree Project aim to replant native broadleaf forest that feeds wildlife and holds the soil and water. To replant well we must first **know which mother trees we already have** — and children are the perfect people to find them.
- **The school sits in the forest.** Mitsue Elementary is in Sugano (菅野) — the same valley as the project's reforestation demonstration area. The study site is out the window.
- **Real data, real pride.** The children's records become part of the village's official tree map and seed-collection plan. Their names stay attached to every tree they log — a lasting contribution, not a worksheet.

3. What the children actually do

For each tree they find:

1. **Identify it** — with the printed *Heritage Tree Field Guide* (leaf, bark, fruit) — 12 native species with photos.
2. **Locate it** — one tap on the tablet captures GPS automatically.
3. **Measure it** — trunk width, height, estimated age.
4. **Observe it** — seeds, saplings, hollows, wildlife signs, sacred trees.
5. **Photograph it** — whole tree, bark, leaf, fruit.
6. **Save it** — the record joins the village map.

Everything is bilingual and every field has a plain-language tooltip, so no prior botany knowledge is needed.

4. How it fits the curriculum

Subject	Link
Science (生活科・理科)	Observing living things, seasons, measurement, classification
Integrated Studies (総合的な学習の時間)	A term-long inquiry into local community & environment
Social / hometown studies	Knowing Mitsue's land, place names, sacred trees
Maths	Real measurement, tallying, simple graphs of the data
ICT (GIGA Chromebooks + phones)	Purposeful device use: camera, GPS, data entry, maps
Language	Bilingual labels; writing up findings

5. Two ways to run it

A. Summer project (free-study / 自由研究). Each child, with their family, logs 3–10 trees near home over the holidays, then presents their favourite "mother tree" in September.

B. Term activity. 2–3 guided outings per term with the whole class; the map grows year on year and becomes the school's own long-term dataset.

Either can start small — **one class, one afternoon, five trees.**

6. What the Mother Tree Project provides

- The **web app** (<https://trees.mitsue.it>) — free, bilingual, works in any phone/tablet browser; nothing to install.
- **Named class/child accounts** set up in advance.
- Printed **Heritage Tree Field Guide** + paper backup forms.
- An **introductory session** for teachers and a first guided walk.
- A **map & simple report** of the class's trees each term.
- Guidance on **safe, low-impact** fieldwork.
- **Open source & open data** — the whole app is open source (MIT licence) and the collected data is open data (CC0 / public domain) in open formats (CSV, GeoJSON, Parquet). The school, the village or anyone else can freely inspect, reuse and modify it. Repositories: github.com/robouden/mitsue-ai-data-center and codeberg.org/YR-Design/mitsue-ai-data-center (folder `tree-survey/`).

7. What the school provides

- Teacher coordination and class time.
- **A few smartphones for the field** — the app needs real GPS + a data signal to pin and save a tree on the mountain, which the GIGA Chromebooks lack (Wi-Fi-only, no GPS). Staff or family phones are fine; only a handful are needed per outing.
- **GIGA Chromebooks for the classroom** — ideal for reviewing and editing records, viewing the map and preparing presentations on the school Wi-Fi.
- Consent for outdoor activity and use of children's first names.

8. Safety & privacy

- Outings stay on **known, safe paths**; adult supervision throughout; bear/insect precautions per season.
- Accounts use a **display name only** (e.g. first name or class). No home addresses are collected.
- Tree GPS points can be **coarsened** for any sacred or vulnerable trees before public display.
- The tree data is released as **open data (CC0)** so anyone can reuse it; only **non-personal** information (species, location, measurements) is published — no home addresses, and accounts use a display name only.

9. Suggested next step

A **20-minute meeting** with the head teacher and the science / integrated-studies lead to pick a class and a date for one trial afternoon this term. We bring the tablets, the guide, and set everything up.

Contact: Rob Oudendijk — Mitsue Mother Tree Project · oudendijk.biz@gmail.com · <https://trees.mitsue.it>

A Japanese edition of this proposal is available ([mitsue_school_tree_survey_proposal_jp.md](#)).

Sources

- Mitsue Elementary & Junior High School — <https://mitsue-e.sakura.ne.jp/> (name, address 〒 633-1302 奈良県宇陀郡御杖村大字菅野2470, tel/email).
- Companion documents: [mitsue_heritage_tree_field_guide.md](#), [tree-survey/README.md](#), village renewable-energy plan alignment brief.